



KOLKATA

Formerly known as Calcutta, the humid capital of West Bengal is famed for its intellectual prowess. Bengali cuisine is spicy and aromatic, featuring many fish and seafood recipes, such as shrimp *malai* ("with coconut") curry.

Bhojohori Manna inexpensive

18/1A Hindustan Road; www.bhojohorimanna.com

The original branch of a small citywide chain churns out delicious Bengali fish and shrimp favorites as well as some tandoori dishes.

Kewpie's Kitchen moderate

2 Elgin Lane; +91 33 2475 9880

The best Bengali cuisine you can get aside from home-cooking, perhaps because the restaurant is the annex to a private home. As well as *malai* curry, you can get *malai chingri*, shrimp in cream.

6 Ballygunge Place expensive

6 Ballygunge Place; +91 33 2460 3922

Catering to the wealthier sector of Kolkata society, this classy restaurant places as much emphasis on its ambience and decor as on the freshly prepared seafood, including fish wrapped in banana leaf.

GOA

Goa is a former Portuguese colony, and the Christian culinary influence is evident in the presence of pork and wine, both rare in India. Fiery vindaloo, derived from the Portuguese *carne de vinha d'Alhos* (a wine-marinated pork dish) may contain both.

Cafe Xavier inexpensive

141 Municipal Market, Mapusa; +91 832 226 2229

This is an ideal place for a vindaloo, amid Goa's biggest market. You can also sample *xacuti*, meat or fish cooked in another fiery sauce of lemon juice, coconut milk, nuts, and red chili peppers.

George Restaurant & Bar inexpensive

Church Square, Panaji; +91 944 405 3656

A favorite local hangout that serves authentic Goan-Catholic cuisine, including vindaloo, kingfish curry, and shrimp-stuffed *papad* (poppadoms).

Ordo Sounsar moderate

North end of beach, Palolem; www.ordosounsar.com

This is a top beach-resort restaurant for sampling real Goan food, not dumbed-down for the Western palate. Try vindaloo-hot shrimp *balchao*, in chili pepper sauce, or shark *ambotik*, a hot-and-sour preparation.

HYDERABAD

Hyderabad is south India's most Islamic city but also the capital of overwhelmingly Hindu Andhra Pradesh. These two influences have combined to produce the biryani, a risotto-style dish of rice with vegetables or meat.

Paradise Persis inexpensive

Mahatma Gandhi Road, Secunderabad; www.paradisefoodcourt.com

This very popular spot in the thick of Hyderabad's twin city cooks delicious biryanis and other west Asian delights, such as mutton kebabs.

Hotel Shadab moderate

Madina Circle, Patthargatti; +91 40 2456 1648

A highly rated biryani joint situated between the river and the heart of the Muslim Old City, this has added fish and meat tandoori dishes to its menu and has an air-conditioned dining hall.

Firdaus expensive

Taj Krishna Hotel, Banjara Hills; +91 40 6666 2323

Biryanis are just one among many exquisite Indian dishes that you can feast upon in the chandelier-lit opulence of this luxury-class hotel restaurant.

RAJASTHAN

The colorful state of Rajasthan is a tapestry of desert, arable land, and imposing forts and palaces. The arid environment and roving lifestyle of the Rajputs (wealthy landowners) led to the development of a cuisine light on vegetables, such as *gatta* (dumpling) curry.

Monica inexpensive

First Fort Gate, Jaisalmer

Right by the entrance to the Arabian Nights-style fort, this modest but extremely popular restaurant serves a variety of Rajasthani dishes, including *gatta* curry and *thalis* (see pp208–9), as well as tandoori.

Chokhi Dhani moderate

Tonk Road, near Jaipur; www.chokhidhani.com

Dining in this theme-park-style restaurant complex is a unique experience; try the filling Rajasthani *thali* that includes *gatta* curry.

Marwar expensive

Taj Hari Mahal Hotel, Jodhpur; +91 291 243 9700

This is a fine place to treat yourself to luxurious surroundings and the traditional Marwari cuisine of Rajasthan, including *gatta di subzi*, a vegetable and dumpling combination, and *mas*, a spicy mutton dish.

